

Squish

A stompbox compressor with two characters - a squishy, gritty sustainer and a clean studio compressor - and a big BLEND knob for parallel compression.



Overview

Squish is a pedal compressor with two modes, designed from scratch in the spirit of the classic orange and red guitar sustainer pedals and the modern boutique studio-style pedal compressors. Both modes share the same four controls - SENS, SUSTAIN, ATTACK and RELEASE - and the mode sets the character behind them. The pedal turns orange-red for VINTAGE and steel blue for STUDIO.

VINTAGE is the sustainer: strong ratios, an aggressive squish and a release that stretches out on long, heavy compression, so it holds notes without pumping. Hit it hard and it adds a little lopsided grit, while quiet playing stays clean. STUDIO is a clean, transparent compressor with gentler ratios and a steadier release.

BLEND, the big knob, mixes the dry signal back under the compressed one, so you can keep your pick attack while the notes sustain. Make-up gain is automatic, and there is no latency (with OFF or CLIP on the output), so it is safe for live guitar monitoring.

Reach for it for

- Country and funk guitar with that squashed, clucky attack
- Long, singing lead sustain
- Even, punchy bass
- Parallel compression that keeps the transients
- Smoothing strummed acoustic guitar
- Gentle glue on a vocal

Controls

The header

PRESETS, ◀ ▶ and the display	PRESETS (or a click on the display) opens the list of factory presets; ◀ and ▶ step through them, and the display shows the one in use. A new instance opens on Init.
S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window. A new instance opens in Large.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Mode

VINTAGE / STUDIO	The character (VINTAGE by default). The name and description printed on the pedal follow it. VINTAGE: ratios from about 2:1 to 20:1, a firm knee, a release that stretches on heavy compression, and grit when hit hard. STUDIO: ratios from about 1.5:1 to 8:1, a softer knee, a release that lengthens only a touch, and no grit. Switching is smooth.
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The compressor

The same four controls in both modes.

SENS	How early it grabs, 0 to 100% (50% by default). It sets the threshold from about -10 dBFS (0%) down to -40 dBFS (100%); the knob shows both. In VINTAGE it also sets how hard the input drives the grit.
SUSTAIN	How much it squashes, 0 to 100% (50% by default). It sets the ratio - about 2:1 to 20:1 in VINTAGE, 1.5:1 to 8:1 in STUDIO - and the knee tightens as it goes up. The knob shows the ratio.
ATTACK	How fast it clamps down, 0.5 - 50 ms (3 ms by default). Slower settings let more of the pick attack through before it squashes.
RELEASE	How fast it lets go, 30 - 1500 ms (140 ms by default). In VINTAGE it stretches up to three times longer on long, heavy compression; in STUDIO only a little.

Gain reduction

Meter	A 12-segment ladder of the gain reduction, 1 to 24 dB: amber up to 8 dB, red beyond.
dB GR readout	The gain reduction in dB.
OTA GRIT / CLEAN VCA	In VINTAGE (OTA GRIT) the lamp glows as the input drives the compressor into grit. In STUDIO it reads CLEAN VCA and stays dark.

TONE and LEVEL

TONE	A tilt at 3 kHz, -100 to +100% (FLAT by default): left darkens (DARK), right adds sparkle (SPARK), up to 9 dB either way. It comes after BLEND, so it shapes the whole sound.
LEVEL	Output level, -24 to +12 dB (0 dB by default). Make-up gain is already automatic (about 70% of the reduction at a

typical level), so use this to match the bypassed loudness.

IN / OUT

TRIM	Input level before anything else, -24 to +12 dB. Raising it works like raising SENS, but also drives the grit harder.
GUARD	Click the TRIM knob (without turning it) to switch GUARD on or off; the small light at the knob's upper right shows it is on and glows brighter while it works. On by default. Gently eases very hot sources down towards about -18 dBFS average and catches fast peaks above -6 dBFS. It never boosts quiet sources.
DRIFT	0 to 100% (15% by default). See Drift below.
OFF / CLIP / LIMIT	The final stage: nothing, a soft clipper at -0.3 dBFS (no latency), or a lookahead limiter (3 ms latency, compensated by REAPER). CLIP is on by default and flashes red while it clips. For live monitoring use OFF or CLIP.

BLEND

BLEND	The big knob: dry / compressed balance, 0 to 100% wet (100% by default). Lower settings bring the uncompressed signal back underneath - parallel compression - so the transients return while the sustain stays. The two stay perfectly in phase, even with the grit.
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In REAPER's parameter list only

On / bypass	Bypass / On (On by default). Bypass crossfades over 10 ms to the raw input, before TRIM; the output stage stays in. There is no key for it on the panel; use REAPER's own bypass, or automate this parameter.
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Drift

DRIFT gives the pedal an uneven supply: the threshold wanders very slightly (up to about 1.5 dB either way at 100%), and so does the bias that sets how lopsided the

grit is. At 0% it stays exactly where you set it.

Knobs: drag up or down (Shift for fine moves); double-click to reset a knob to its default. The mouse wheel works too.

Presets

Presets set the mode, the four compressor controls, BLEND, TONE, LEVEL and DRIFT, and switch the plug-in on (out of bypass). TRIM, GUARD and the output stage are left as they are.

Init	VINTAGE with every control at its default: a medium squish at 100% wet.
Country Chicken Pickin'	VINTAGE, quite heavy, a little dry blended in and a bright tone, for clucky, snappy picking.
Funk Squish	VINTAGE, very heavy and fully wet with a touch of sparkle, LEVEL down 1 dB.
Clean Sustain	STUDIO, moderate, with a slower attack and a long 420 ms release; 80% wet.
Parallel Punch	STUDIO, hard and fast, blended 50 / 50 with the dry signal: punchy parallel compression.
Bass Even-Out	STUDIO, moderate, with a slow 15 ms attack, a 300 ms release and a slightly darker tone, for bass.
Acoustic Strum	STUDIO, light, with a 20 ms attack to keep the strum and a brighter tone; 70% wet.
Lead Sustain	VINTAGE, very sensitive and very heavy, for long, singing notes.
Vocal Glue	STUDIO, gentle, with a 350 ms release and a touch of air: light levelling for a vocal.
Slide Sustain	VINTAGE, heavy with a slightly darker tone and a little more drift, 75% wet.

Tips

- Set SENS first, until the meter shows a few dB of reduction on your normal playing, then shape it with SUSTAIN.
- For more pick attack, lengthen ATTACK or lower BLEND. BLEND keeps the attack natural; ATTACK makes it snappier.
- Watch the OTA GRIT lamp in VINTAGE: if you want it clean, lower SENS or TRIM until the lamp barely glows.
- Compression brings up noise as well as sustain. A little DARK on TONE helps with a noisy guitar.
- Compare with REAPER's bypass and set LEVEL so the loudness matches before you judge it.

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